

The Tense-Mood-Aspect System of Makista

Abstract

Makista, the Macao Portuguese Creole, is an understudied endangered language. This essay explores the Tense-Mood-Aspect(TMA) system of Makista by considering the grammatical and semantic properties of the three overt TMA markers: *já*, *lôgo* and *ta*. Examples are collected from José dos Santos Ferreiro's poems and existing scholarly literature by Pinharanda-Nunes. Results reveal that *já* is a past marker in tense, and a perfective marker in aspect; *lôgo* is a future marker in tense, and an irrealis marker in mood; *ta* is a non-punctual marker in aspect. The study provides empirical evidence for the research of Ibero-Romance-based creoles, and contributes to the field of creole study.

Keywords: Makista , Macao, Tense-Mood-Aspect system

1 Introduction

The Tense-Mood-Aspect (TMA) systems of various creole languages have intrigued many linguists. Creoles are languages developed from close contact between mutually unintelligible indigenous languages and foreign languages, mostly due to international trades, or colonisation. When foreign settlers came, pidgins were firstly formed, which can be regarded as the predecessors of creoles. When these pidgins are passed on to the next generation, forming a relatively stable structure, and having native speakers, creoles are

created.

The formation and development of creoles usually involve language acquisition. Bickerton (1975, 1981, 1984) proposed the language bioprogram hypothesis (LBH), after studying the structural similarities between different creoles from the perspective of language acquisition. He asserts that there should be a prototypical system that explains the similarity in the formation and development of creoles. He believes that the default TMA system for creoles includes three subdivisions, namely *anterior tense*, *irrealis mood* and *nonpunctual aspects*, and is invariant in the order of tense, mood and aspect. We refer to this framework as the TMA system in the analysis of creoles. The anterior tense is also known as a relative past tense, which refers to a time located prior to a determined temporal reference point. The English construction 'having done' expresses the anterior tense. The irrealis mood is associated with an event's unpredictability and is used for unforeseeable futures, conditionals and subjunctives. An English construction with the irrealis mood is 'would'. Non-punctual aspects are also referred to as durative aspects, meaning that they describe actions lasting for a certain period of time, not a point. For example, the word 'walking' in the English phrase 'walking in the street' is non-punctual, whereas 'walk' in 'walk inside the classroom' is punctual.

The postulation of the LBH was a milestone in the study of creoles. Some descriptive literatures on creoles have employed the TMA framework in the hypothesis to analyse creole

structures. Among the earliest of these studies were a series of articles edited by Singler (1990), which included various analyses on the TMA systems of Haitian Creole, Cape Verdean Creole, Papiamentu, and other creole languages. These papers revealed that TMA systems may not be found in all creole languages and that the system varies from language to language, yet this framework is still practical in the analysis of creoles.

Makista, also called Macao Patois or Portuguese Creole of Macao, belongs to the broader group of creoles based on Ibero-Romance languages, which mainly refer to Portuguese and Spanish. Recent studies have indicated that there is less consistency in the TMA systems of Ibero-Romance-based creoles than that of French-based creoles. According to Bollée and Maurer (2016), all Ibero-Romance-based creoles discriminate between imperfective and perfective aspects, but some mark present and past in tense, others do not, and some have other tense categories, such as pluperfect. Atlantic creoles distinguish both tense and aspect. For example, Papiamentu (a Spanish- and Portuguese-based creole spoken in the Dutch Caribbean) uses *lo* as a future marker, *ta* as an imperfective present marker, *tabata* as a past imperfective marker, and *a* as a perfective marker. Some South Asian creoles have additional TMA markers. For instance, Korlai (a Portuguese-based creole spoken in Korlai, India) has a pluperfect marker *ti-d*. We may explain the grammatical differences between these creoles as a result of the influence from indigenous languages. The most complex TMA systems are found among the Portuguese-based creoles spoken in South Asia,

while the simplest TMA systems are found among the Portuguese-based creoles used in South-east Asia. The distinctive grammatical properties of Tamil and Malay may account for the differences in TMA markers between the two groups of creoles.

This essay starts with a description of the history and social status of Makista, exploring the possible impacts of other languages on its formation. Subsequently, we elaborate on the TMA system of Makista with reference to examples from within and across the language. We concluded by a summary of the properties of the TMA markers in Makista.

2 The History and Current Social Status of Makista

To better understand the TMA system of Makista, it is necessary to investigate the origin of this Creole. Makista is a Portuguese-based creole spoken by less than 50 people in the Macao Special Administrative Region of south-eastern China. It is considered to be "critically endangered". The birth of the language is attributed to the Portuguese expansion in Asia, with Portuguese merchants and commissioners travelling to and settling in Macao, beginning in the 16th century. Portuguese merchant ships anchored seasonally, and in later centuries, a Portuguese territory was established in Asia that ranged from the west coast of India, through Sri Lanka, Malacca, and the present-day Indonesian Archipelago and East Timor. In the case of Makista's development, Portuguese came into close contact with the local Cantonese (a Chinese dialect originated in the central Guangdong Province, south-east of China) and also mingled with Malay, English, and other languages used within the

territory. Kristang, a Portuguese-based creole used in Malacca, Malaysia, is known to have largely influenced Makista. Makista has absorbed many Malay lexicons and grammatical properties from Kristang. The two languages are mutually intelligible. Speakers of Makista sometimes refer to their language as Kristang. However, for clarity, we will refer to the Macao Creole as Makista and the Malacca Creole as Kristang in this essay. During Portuguese rule, there was diglossia in the Asian societies within the territory, which means, the H language (the language with prestige) , the standard Portuguese in this case, was used in the official administration, while the L languages (the vernacular languages) were more popular in actual daily communication. Throughout the Portuguese rule, local ethnic groups were not allowed to fill administrative positions, yet they needed to communicate with the Portuguese officers. Several languages therefore developed serving as pidgins for inter-language communication. Gradually, some of these languages have become the lingua franca throughout the territory. In the South-east Asian Portuguese colony, the lingua franca was Kristang. Pinharanda-Nunes (2012) contends that Kristang may have been widely used among traders and fishermen in Macao, even before the Portuguese rule.

Pinharanda-Nunes (2012) indicates that the formation of Makista and Kristang are divergent. Kristang is heavily influenced by the local language of Malay, and possibly by Hokkien (a Chinese dialect originated in the southern Fujian Province, south-east of China), considering that many Chinese residents from the South-eastern coast were trading and living

in Malaysia and Singapore during the centuries. Significant Chinese societies both exist in the case of Kristang and Makista, which may also explain the similarity between the two creoles. However, Cantonese might not have played a vital role in the formation of Makista, unlike the central role of Malay in the formation of Kristang. In essence, Makista is developed from the lingua franca Kristang, and can therefore be considered as a variety of Kristang influenced by Cantonese.

The linguistic context of Macao is not beneficial for the spread of Makista in the present day. In contemporary Macao, the most commonly spoken languages are Cantonese, Mandarin, and English. Makista is no longer used for communication, but is rather a cultural emblem. It appears in various artistic performances. On 20 December, 1999, Macao became the second Special Administrative Region in China under the 'One country, two systems' framework. After that, the Chinese government has implemented the language policy of 三語四文 (translated as 'three written languages and four spoken languages'), which declares that three languages, namely Chinese, Portuguese and English, should be used in education and official documents. One should notice that Chinese is a unique language; although speakers of Chinese dialects use the same character in the written form, the pronunciations of a given character differ among Chinese dialects, and these dialects are mutually unintelligible in the spoken form. In the context of Macao, therefore, the written Chinese can be split into Cantonese and Mandarin. The four spoken languages are thus Cantonese, Mandarin,

Portuguese and English. Although Portuguese is regulated as an official language, considering the history of Portuguese colonisation, there are only about 6,200 native Portuguese speakers in Macao, accounting for less than 1% of the population, according to a census in 2014. Portuguese is unpopular in Macao, as is needless to say, the moribund Makista. The Macao Portuguese Creole exists mainly as a cultural symbol for the Eurasian Macanese¹, an ethnic group resulting from inter-marriage between Portuguese and local Chinese. Nowadays, most Macao residents speak Cantonese as their mother tongue. Some non-official organisations have been established to revitalise Makista. One such organisation is 'Dóci Papiçám di Macau' (translated as 'the sweet talks of Macao')², which regularly arranges shows to enable people to enjoy the beauty of the language.

3 Methodology

Makista is an under-studied language. Some literatures on the subject have been published by the team led by Mário Pinharanda-Nunes from the University of Macao. They attempted to explore the genesis and development of the language. This essay is inspired largely by their research.

This essay explores the TMA system of Makista. Makista data are drawn mainly from José dos Santos Ferreira's collections of poetry. Ferreira, also known as Adé, was the son of a

¹ 'Macanese' is a term used specifically to refer to the Eurasian ethnic group, and not used to talk about the general Macao residents, many of whom are Cantonese Chinese in the ethnic background.

² This organisation has an official youtube channel: <https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxRaAKi5QGPlfGi3Vbr8Ngg>, which posts various shows presented in Makista.

Portuguese father and a Macanese mother. He was the last poet to write in Makista. Ferreira lived all his life in Macao and left behind a great body of work, consisting of 18 books of poetry, prose, plays, operettas, and radio shows in Makista. Considering the flexibility of language use in poetry, some minor revisions may have been made to Ferreira's work to better illustrate the argument made. According to Bollée and Maurer (2016), South-east Asian Portuguese creoles use only a future marker, an imperfective marker and a perfective marker. We will thus compare such features to Makista to determine whether this assumption is true in the case of Makista. We will also evaluate the TMA system of Makista with Bickerton's (1981) assumption about the prototypical TMA system of creoles. Because Makista has no standard orthography, some inconsistency in spellings may occur, which are not necessarily incorrect.

4 Results and Discussions

We have detected three TMA markers in Makista: *já*, *lôgo*, and *ta*. We will discuss their grammatical and semantic functions one by one in the subsequent sections.

4.1 The Past-Perfective Marker 'Já'

Já comes from the Portuguese adverb *já* ('already'). It can be a past marker in tense and a perfective marker in aspect. When followed by a dynamic verb, *já* has a perfective indication. It is used for the simple past and perfective tenses.

(1) Past / Perfective

Macau já nasceu, já creceu.

Macao PST³ be born PFV⁴ grow

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 28)

'Macao was born and has grown' as a preferred translation.

When followed by a stative verb, which describes the condition of an object, *já* reveals a change of state.

(2) Past / Perfective

Macau já ficou inchente.

Macao PFV remain crowded

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 35)

'Macao became crowded.' or 'Macao has become crowded.'

Já tends not to co-occur with negation. To express 'did not' or 'have not done', Makista would use the adverb *nunca* ('never'), which functions similarly to the Portuguese *nunca* ('never')

(3) Past-Negation / Perfective-Negation

Eu nunca vi o diabo.

I NEG.PST⁵ see devil

(Makista, Ferreira 1996: 72)

³ PST indicates past.

⁴ PFV indicates perfective.

⁵ NEG indicates negation.

'I did not see the devil' or 'I have not seen the devil.'

The Cantonese verbal markers 咗 and 過 may have influenced the semantic value of the perfective aspect marker *já*. Pinharanda-Nunes (2012) revealed three semantic values of 咗, namely "(a) to mark a result; (b) refers to a situation without a result; and (c) refers to a time span extending until and including the present." Regarding 過, it is used to express a remote experience in an indefinite past that has no relevance to the present. The following two Cantonese sentences are proposed to illustrate the usage of the two verbal markers based on my native-speaker knowledge.

(5) Perfective

今日 你 飲 咗 未?

Today you drink **PFV** yet

(Cantonese, based on native-speaker knowledge)

'Have you already drunk today?'

This is a popular advertising slogan in the Cantonese-speaking China, advocating the audience to drink yoghurt every day. 咗 here functions as a marker that refers to a situation with a result and indicates a time span expanding until now.

(6) Past

我 喺 曼徹斯特大學 學 過 語言學。

I at University of Manchester study **PST** linguistics

(Cantonese, based on native-speaker knowledge)

'I once studied linguistics at the University of Manchester.'

This sentence has no perfective indication; it specifies only an action that took place in the indefinite past. The action has no relevance to the present, being an objective description of the past, similar to the simple past in English.

The Makista marker *já* thus combines the semantic functions of the two Cantonese markers. The English equivalences for *já* can be either the simple past or various perfective tenses, according to the contexts. *Já* is both a past and a perfective marker.

4.2 The Future-Irrealis Marker '*Lôgo*'

Lôgo comes from the Portuguese adverb *logo* ('later'). It can be a future marker in tense and an irrealis marker in mood. The following example illustrates *lôgo* as a future marker. In such cases, it tends to co-occur with dynamic verbs to indicate actions or changes in the future.

(7) Future

*Tanto ancua dóci di Macau certo **lôgo** desaparecê.*

So many thing sweet of Macau certainly **FUT**⁶ disappear

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 22)

'So many sweet things of Macao will disappear.'

⁶ FUT indicates future.

Lôgo tends not to co-occur with negation. To express 'will not', Makista would use the adverb *nádi* ('will not'), derived from the Portuguese *não há de* ('not have to').

(8) Future-Negation

Iou nádi vai Ongcông!

I NEG.FUT go Hong Kong

(Makista, Ferreira 1996: 41)

'I will not go to Hong Kong.'

Lôgo can be used in a conditional sentence to indicate a hypothesis. It can also be used in a sentence with the past tense to indicate irrealis. Sentence (9) is an example of conditional irrealis, and sentence (10) functions as a irrealis with regards to the contradiction between past and present.

(9) Conditional Irrealis

Se teng gente veng, igual ôcê assim veng,

COND have people come same you like this come

nós logo encontra.

we IRR⁷ meet

(Makista, Pinharanda-Nunes 2019: 436)

'If someone like you comes, we will meet (him/her).'

⁷ IRR indicates irrealis.

(10) Past-Irrealis

*Ele antis tem unga motorbike, nos **logo** vai senta motorbike.*

He previously have a motorbike, we **IRR** go sit motorbike.

(Makista, Pinharanda-Nunes 2019: 437)

'Previously, he had a motorbike; we would sit on the motorbike.'

Lôgo can be used with various aspects, Baxter and Pinharanda-Nunes (2004)

investigated the use of *lôgo* with the perfective, continuous, and habitual aspects in the past tense. Pinharanda-Nunes (2019) identified the use of *lôgo* in the present tense with the continuous and habitual aspects. As *lôgo* is not specific to any aspect, we may conclude that *lôgo* is not an aspect marker. It is a future marker in tense and an irrealis marker in mood.

4.3 Non-punctual Aspect Marker 'Ta'

Ta comes from the Portuguese verb *estar* ('to be'). It is sometimes referred to as a imperfective marker. It can co-occur with dynamic verbs, but may not with stative verbs. As indicated by the term 'non-punctual', the verbs following *ta* should be always continuous in aspect, meaning they last for a linear period of time, rather than being a point on the time axis. The marker *ta* indicates no tense and can be used in past, present, or future.

(11) Present-Imperfective

*Estunga Mundo únde nós **ta** vivo,*

This world where we **IPFV**⁸ live

têm quelê tánto ancuza dóci.

have so many things sweet

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 21)

'In the world where we live, there are so many sweet things.'

(12) Future-Imperfective

Macau ta perto falá adios pa Portugal.

Macao **IPFV** almost say goodbye for Portugal

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 27)

'Macao is about to say Goodbye to Portugal.'

(13) Past-Imperfective

Unga dia pramicedo, iou ta olá Macau co tudo amigo.

One day early morning, I **IPFV** see Macao with all friend

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 85)

'One early morning, I was seeing Macao with all my friends.'

Ta can co-occur with negation, see the subsequent example.

⁸ IPFV indicates imperfective.

(14) Present-Imperfective-Negation

Istréla ta nom-têm fim di briliá

star **IPFV** not-have end of shine

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 64)

'The star does not stop shining.'

From the examples above, we conclude that the marker *ta* does not differentiate tense and mood. As an aspect marker, it can co-occur with negation. It can be interpreted as an imperfective marker or a non-punctual aspect marker.

4.4 Zero Tense-Mood-Aspect Marker

Based the examples in sections 4.1 to 4.3, we may conclude that TMA markers are preverbal. The absence of a TMA marker before a verb may express a range of meanings related to tense, mood and aspect.

Absence of a TMA marker before a verb may indicate an imperative mood.

(15) Zero TMA marker in Imperative

$\emptyset$ *Vêm pa Macau!*

$\emptyset$ come to Macao

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 16)

'Come to Macao!'

Absence of a TMA marker may indicate the habitual aspect, sharing some similar functions with the imperfective marker *ta*. *Ta* is not always necessary to express an imperfective aspect; in some cases, *ta* is even forbidden. For transient verbs, which describe actions ending within a short time and that cannot be mapped by a line on the time axis, *ta* may not be used to indicate habitual aspect. Also, as we have discussed in 4.3, *ta* tends not to be followed by a stative verb. In this case, *ta* and copulas do not co-occur. The English 'be' serves as a pertinent examples of copulas, which connects a subject and its complement, defining the condition of a subject. Copulas are not dynamic in nature, and tend to be grouped as stative verbs. In sentence (16), *começá* ('to begin') is a transient verb, because one cannot keep beginning. Thus, *ta* cannot co-occur with *começá*.

(16) Zero TMA marker before a transient verb

Macau $\emptyset$ *começá* *su* *vida*.

Macao $\emptyset$ begin its life.

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 28)

'Macau begins its life.'

(17) Zero TMA marker before a copula

Macau $\emptyset$ *sã* *unga* *cidádi*.

Macao $\emptyset$ be one city

(Makista, Ferreira 1990: 29)

'Macao is a city.'

The following two sentences are very similar to each other in meaning, sentence (18) is without *ta*, and sentence (19) is with *ta*. Both sentences can be translated as either 'I go to school', or 'I am going to school.', but the first example emphasises the daily routine, whereas the second example emphasises the continuous and imperfective actions.

(18) *Iou* $\emptyset$ *vai* *iscóla*.

I $\emptyset$ go school

(Makista, Jr 2020: 86)

'I go to school' as a preferred translation.

(19) *Iou* *ta* *vai* *iscóla*.

I **IPFV** go school.

(Makista, Jr 2020: 86)

'I am going to school' as a preferred translation.

In sum, when no overt TMA marker precedes a verb, the sentence can be either imperative or can indicate the habitual aspect. The non-punctual aspect marker *ta* can sometimes be omitted.

4.5 A Comparison with Previous Assumptions

Bickerton (1981) argued that the default TMA system of creoles is anterior tense, irrealis mood, and non-punctuative aspect. The TMA markers of Makista do not diverge much from

the assumed prototypical TMA model. *Já* corresponds to the anterior tense, *lôgo* to the irrealis mood and *ta* to the non-punctuative aspects. However, each of these markers in Makista may perform diverse semantic functions. *Já* also suggests a perfective aspect, and *lôgo* can also be used in both realis and irrealis moods to indicate future. Just as Makista does not fit neatly into Bickerton's default TMA system, Bollée and Maurer's (2016) conclusion on South-eastern Asian Portuguese creoles is over-simplified, but generally true.

5 Conclusion and Outlook

Based on our analysis, we have detected three overt TMA markers in Makista: the past-perfective marker *já*, the future-irrealis marker *lôgo*, and the non-punctual aspect marker *ta*. They function complementarily to express tenses, moods, and aspects. *Já* and *lôgo* cannot co-occur with negations. To express past or perfect in negations, speakers instead use *nunca*; to express a negated future, speakers use *nádi*. There seems to be some distinction between dynamic and stative verbs in meaning when they are combined with different TMA markers. However, no concrete or convincing conclusions could be reached according to our current investigation. Although TMA markers perform various syntactic and semantic functions in expressing tenses, moods and aspects, we notice that a sentence without an overt marker can also have its specific tense, mood, or aspect.

This essay strives to provide readers with some knowledge of the three overt TMA markers in the language, and contributes to the field of creole study by providing empirical

evidence from Makista, a critically understudied language. Most existing literature on the grammatical properties of this language is published by Mário Pinharanda-Nunes. More attention should be drawn to this endangered language. Sufficient language materials are provided online, including Ferreiro's literary works and many other historical documents. These materials are precious for the study of Makista.

This study has some limitations. To begin, we have not discovered combinations of different TMA markers in the investigated poems, thus cannot test Bickerton's (1981) assumption about the order of TMA markers. Furthermore, there are no existing English or Portuguese translations of Ferreira's Makista text, which may lead to inaccuracies during the illustration in the usage of the markers. Finally, lack of speakers is a limitation not specific to this study. Currently, there are fewer than 50 native speakers of Makista, and many of them are elderly.

Future directions of research include a more thorough investigation of the TMA system's functioning in various situations. The current essay has investigated only simple predicates with a single verb. However, TMA is not specific to single verbs, and may co-occur with more complex predicates. Additionally, this study has provided scant discussion on the moods of Makista, which are versatile and worth further consideration. Hopefully, more detailed studies on Makista will be carried out in the future.

[Word Count: 3848 words]

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